

# Academic Writing vs. Technical Communication

*Different goals. Different audiences. Different approaches.*

## Academic Writing

**Writing to demonstrate what you know.**

FROM  
"WHAT I  
KNOW"  
TO  
"WHAT YOU  
NEED"

## Technical Communication

**Designing information so someone can use it.**

|                                                                                                               |                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Demonstrates knowledge, develops an argument, or contributes to scholarly discussion.                         | <br>Purpose            | Helps readers understand information, make decisions, or take action.                                                                 |
| Usually instructors, students, or scholars.                                                                   | <br>Audience           | Clients, coworkers, managers, specialists, users, or the public.                                                                      |
| Demonstrates understanding and builds a well-supported interpretation or argument.                            | <br>Writer's Role      | Provides information readers need to accomplish a specific goal.                                                                      |
| Often follows conventional essay or disciplinary structures.                                                  | <br>Organization       | Designed around readers' needs and how they will use the document.                                                                    |
| Often intended for sustained, beginning-to-end reading.                                                       | <br>Reading Pattern  | Often designed for scanning, skimming, and selective reading.                                                                         |
| Emphasizes scholarly research, analysis, and citation.                                                        | <br>Evidence         | Uses the evidence most useful and credible for the situation, including research, data, standards, testing, and expert knowledge.     |
| Often develops ideas through extended explanation and analysis.                                               | <br>Style            | Prioritizes clarity, concision, precision, and usability.                                                                             |
| Formatting often follows established academic conventions. Visuals usually supplement the written discussion. | <br>Design & Visuals | Headings, lists, tables, graphics, white space, and typography help communicate information. Visuals can carry essential information. |
| The reader understands and accepts the writer's analysis or argument.                                         | <br>Success Means    | The reader can find, understand, and use the information effectively.                                                                 |

## The Big Takeaway



**Academic writing**  
shows what you know.

**Technical communication**  
focuses on what your reader needs.



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